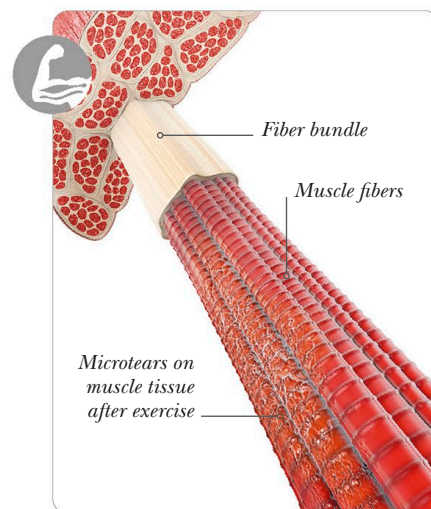


» CLOSER LOOK

Dancer strikes a balance between stability and mobility, along with effort and ease. Muscles build in strengthening poses like this when microtears heal.

*Elbow soft,
not locked*

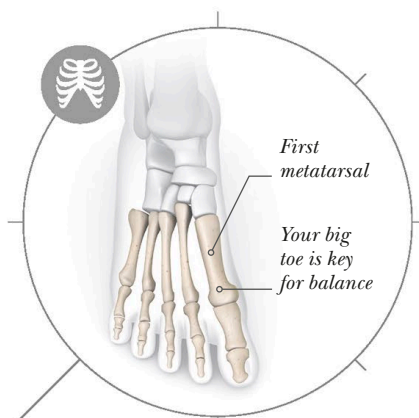
*Neck muscles stabilize
chin, lifting slightly*



How muscles build

Throughout your life, you can't grow more skeletal muscle cells. Instead, the cells can grow larger in diameter. After exercising, your muscle cells are left damaged—covered in microtears—as a response to the beneficial stress on your tissue. Your body sends nutrients to the area, helping it heal and become even stronger than before.

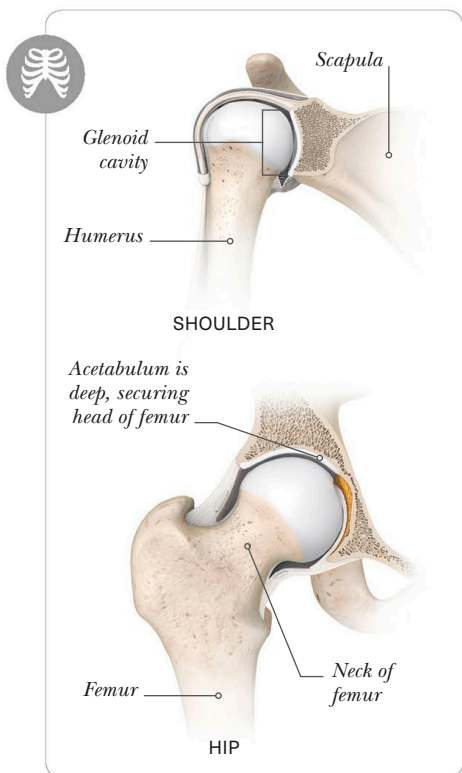
*Adductors engage
and lengthen*



Toe joints

In poses like Dancer, spreading your toes helps you to balance. It can also counteract hallux valgus (bunions) in which the big toe turns inward, leading to bone deformity and inflammation around the joint.

ANTERIOR VIEW



Ball and socket joints

Both your shoulder and hip joints are ball and socket joints (see pp.16–17). Your shoulder joint is shallow with a lot of mobility; it is only limited by ligaments and muscles. Your hip joint, in contrast, is deeper with more joint structures to help hold it securely in place.